

child and adopted daughter of the influential poet Giulio Strozzi. Her mother, Isabella Garzoni, was a servant and possibly also a courtesan (a high-class prostitute) of Giulio's. A member of the Accademia degli Incogniti (Academy of the Unknowns, see [box](#)), Giulio used his elite connections to promote his daughter's musical talents, and sent her off to study with the prominent composer and pioneer of opera Francesco Cavalli.

A woman's work

By 1637, aged 18, Strozzi had made a name for herself as a virtuoso singer, and in 1644 she launched her career as a female composer with the publication of her First Book of Madrigals for two to four voices.

By her early thirties, she had four children. Their father was probably Giovanni Vidman, patron of the arts and a friend of her father. However, Strozzi was a single mother and never married. Unsubstantiated accounts suggest she was also a courtesan.

Following the death of her father in 1652, Strozzi published numerous works (no doubt for financial reasons): more than 100 pieces of secular vocal music—ariettas; arias; and lengthy, complex cantatas—and a book of sacred songs. Most of her music is for solo soprano and focuses on themes of love and desire. Her work is notable for her sensitivity to text and to sound.

Conspicuously absent from Strozzi's compositions and performances is opera, despite the fact that it was such a fashionable new genre. As scholars Diane Jezic and Elizabeth Wood have suggested, her gender confined her to the private